caste census the basis for extending a slew of welfare schemes and recalibrating reservations. But a clear majority—59 per cent—thinks that reservations should be based solely on a person's economic status and not the caste, up from 57.3 per cent a year ago. Simultaneously, there's a perceptible fall in the percentage of those wanting both criteria to be considered—from 32.3 to 27.9.

Amid a spate of pre-poll guarantees, those who agree that both the Union and state governments should give more 'freebies' are on the increase. In just a year, the number has gone up from 49 per cent to 52.6 per cent of the respondents. Talking of elections, a key outcome of the state assembly polls held in November 2023 is the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress making novel choices as chief ministers. So while the BJP went for new faces in Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, ignoring the claims of veterans, even the Congress picked a leader in Telangana who has never held an executive office before. While a vast majority of the respondents—61.3 per cent—endorses this generational shift in state leadership, 22 per cent of them don't agree with it.

Moving from the state assemblies to Parliament, the passage of the Women's Reservation Act is reckoned as a defining moment. MOTN reveals that 40 per cent of the respondents believe it reflects Prime Minister Narendra Modi's commitment to women's empowerment, though a significant 27.3 per cent perceive it is timed to gain electoral advantage in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. Another 13 per cent say that it's a much-needed reform, its timing doesn't matter. There's a small section—3 per cent—which feels that by linking it with the census, it has been made ineffective while a majority—56.9 per cent—say the 33 per cent reservation for women in Parliament should have been implemented from the upcoming general election.

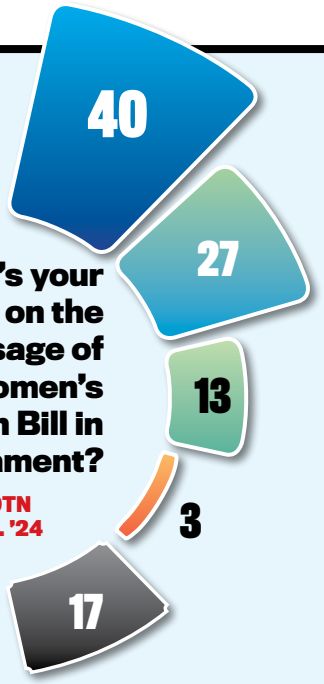
Another prospective legislation in focus is the Uniform Civil Code (UCC). While a majority continues to favour its implementation in India, as revealed in the biannual MOTN polls since January 2021, the figure has gone down from the peak of 72.7 per cent in January 2022 to 62.8 per cent in February 2024. In the same period, the percentage of those against it has gone up from 13.7 per cent to 21.1 per cent. With Uttarakhand taking the lead in pushing for a UCC, further polarisation of opinions is likely to take place over the next year. A blanket ban on polygamy and child marriage, a common marriageable age for girls across all faiths, enforcing similar grounds and procedures for divorce and the mandatory registration of live-in relationships are among the recommendations of a panel that drafted the UCC Bill for the hill state, which was passed by its legislative assembly on February 7.

56.9
PER CENT
RESPONDENTS SAY WOMEN'S RESERVATION SHOULD HAVE BEEN IMPLEMENTED BEFORE THE 2024 LOK SABHA POLL

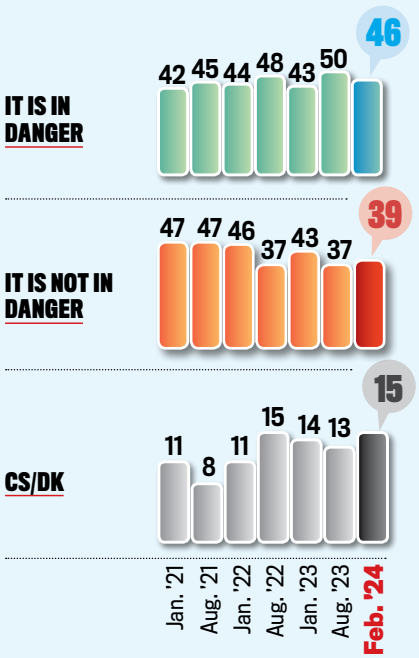
The appointment of judges remains another contentious issue, with no clear majority. Though 37.5 per cent of the respondents think judges should make these appointments themselves, 18.7 per cent believe it should be the prerogative of the executive. Opting for a middle ground, a significant 29 per cent want both

Q. What's your view on the passage of the Women's Reservation Bill in Parliament?

MOTN FEB. '24



Q. What do you think about the current state of democracy in India?



Nearly half the respondents believe that democracy is in danger in India